

FLEXIBLE MEAL PLANNING

FREQUENTLY ASKED QUESTIONS



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TABLE OF CONTENTS

05 INTRODUCTION

06 A QUICK GUIDE TO FLEXIBLE DIETING

08 THE “SECRET” TO FLEXIBLE DIETING

11 FLEXIBLE DIETING AND BODY COMPOSITION

13 FOOD CHOICES AND FLEXIBLE DIETING

16 CHOOSE YOUR OWN MEAL TIMING AND FREQUENCY

FREQUENTLY ASKED QUESTIONS

19 Q1: DO I REALLY NEED TO TRACK MY CALORIES AND MACROS TO GET SHREDDED OR TO BUILD MUSCLE?

20 Q2: CAN I CHANGE THE FOOD ITEMS IN MY FLEXIBLE MEAL PLAN?

20 Q3: SHOULD I WEIGH MY FOOD COOKED OR RAW/UNCOOKED?

22 Q4: ARE MY DAILY TARGET CALORIES “NET CALORIES” OR “TOTAL CALORIES”?

23 **Q5:** CAN YOU PLEASE CHECK MY MEAL PLAN AND CONFIRM MY BODY PERCENTAGE?

23 **Q6:** SHOULD I BE “EATING BACK” THE CALORIES I BURN EVERY DAY?

24 **Q7:** SHOULD I BULK OR CUT FIRST? I’M CONFUSED

26 **Q8:** I’M STRUGGLING TO GET OVER 150 GRAMS OF PROTEIN A DAY! IS IT NECESSARY? ANY IDEAS?

29 **Q9:** WHAT IF I OVER-EAT OR HAVE AN OUTRIGHT BINGE SESSION?

31 **Q10:** HOW MUCH WEIGHT SHOULD I EXPECT TO LOSE PER WEEK WHILE CUTTING?

32 **Q11:** HOW MUCH WEIGHT SHOULD I EXPECT TO BULK PER WEEK?

33 **Q12:** HOW CAN I FIGURE OUT MY APPROXIMATE BODY FAT PERCENTAGE?

33 **Q13:** CAN I INCORPORATE A “CHEAT MEAL” OR “CHEAT DAY” IN MY MEAL PLAN?

35 **Q14:** CAN I DRINK A GLASS OF WINE EVERY NIGHT?

36 **Q15:** DO I NEED TO DO CARDIO WHILE IN A CUTTING PHASE?

38 **Q16:** DO I NEED TO AVOID CARDIO DURING BULKING?

39 **Q17:** HOW DO I KNOW WHEN IT'S TIME TO SWITCH FROM A BULK TO A CUT, AND VICE VERSA?

42 **Q18:** HOW DO I TRANSITION FROM A CUT TO A BULK?

43 **Q19:** CAN I CUT AND BULK AT THE SAME TIME?

43 **Q20:** WON'T I GAIN MUSCLE FASTER IF I EAT AS MUCH AS POSSIBLE, WITHOUT TRACKING MY CALORIES?

45 **Q21:** WHAT WEIGHT TRAINING PROGRAM DO YOU RECOMMEND WHILE ON A CUTTING OR BULKING MEAL PLAN?

47 **Q22:** WHAT BRANDS OF FOOD SHOULD I USE IN MY FLEXIBLE MEAL PLAN?

47 **Q23:** WHEN SHOULD I EAT MY FOOD ON THE FLEXIBLE MEAL PLAN?

49 **Q24:** IS FOOD PREPARATION AN IMPORTANT CONSIDERATION TO MY CUTTING AND BULKING AMBITIONS?

50 **Q25:** WHAT IS THE "80:20 RULE"?

51 **Q26:** WHAT SPORTS OR TRAINING SUPPLEMENTS SHOULD I TAKE?

56 **DISCLAIMER**

INTRODUCTION

Welcome to the *Frequently Asked Questions* guide where I've compiled common questions asked over the years relating to creating a flexible meal plan.

Before emailing your specific question, I highly recommend referring to this guide as it may already answer your question asked by someone else.

There are also embedded video tutorials inside the *Quick Start Guide* which will help you get started on your journey of creating your own flexible meal plan based on your physique goals.

Good luck with your transformation! It's a journey that will change your life forever and that you'll forever look back upon.

Best regards,

Brad

A QUICK GUIDE TO FLEXIBLE DIETING



If only the diet “geniuses” of the world educated you on how weight loss (or fat loss) and your metabolism work, there would be no need to resort to dietary fearmongering and horrendously restrictive diet regimens.

Like most of you reading this, I bought into dieting ideologies that if I wanted to lose fat and build muscle (as a night shift worker), that I had to say goodbye to grains, sugar, fruit, dairy, etc.

One of the biggest ideologies I bought into was the myth of “avoiding carbs after 8 pm” because I believed it would all store as fat. As a night shift worker, this common myth really screwed with me! There were times where I believed I had to quit my night shift job and work a “normal job” to be in the running to get into shape.

Then I learned of IIFYM or “If It Fits Your Macros” or *flexible dieting*. A lifestyle approach to eating which means dramatically transforming your body by eating the foods you enjoy—any time of the day—7 days per week. As a night shift worker... this was a game changer!

Essentially, flexible dieting or IIFYM is a dietary strategy which revolves around eating a certain number of calories, protein, carbs, and fat, according to your body composition goals of either shedding fat or building muscle.

Flexible dieting is a way to take your body’s basic energy and nutritional needs and turn them into an eating regimen that you enjoy, giving you tremendous flexibility in what you can eat. Food such as potatoes, chocolate, ice cream, pizza, pasta, and bread are all acceptable food choices.

THE “SECRET” TO FLEXIBLE DIETING



Flexible dieting works because of a rather simple, yet “boring” physiological concept of [energy balance](#)—or the balance of calories consumed through eating and drinking vs calories burned through exercise. You may have heard of it summarised as “energy in vs energy out.”

Below is a table that summarises the relationship between the amount of energy you eat and the amount you burn when it comes to weight loss and weight gain.

ENERGY BALANCE	
Energy IN = Energy OUT	Weight remains the same
Energy IN > Energy OUT	Weight gain
Energy IN < Energy OUT	Weight loss

When it comes to weight loss (or fat loss), it's just a numbers game and making this simple physiological concept of energy balance work for your body composition ambitions.

Contrary to mainstream dieting advice it doesn't matter what you eat, if you maintain a *moderate calorie deficit* or "negative energy balance" by eating less energy than you burn (i.e., Energy IN < Energy OUT), you will lose weight. In the fitness world, this is also known as "cutting" or "shredding."

When you maintain a *moderate calorie surplus* or "positive energy balance" by eating more energy than you burn (i.e., Energy IN > Energy OUT), you will gain weight. Also referred to as "bulking" or "gaining mass."

Therefore, eating a calorie surplus of the "cleanest" foods in the world can cause *weight gain* while maintaining a calorie deficit on a "vending machine" diet of garbage food will cause *weight loss*.

What most "clean eaters" are not aware of is the nutritional value of food has very little to do with your body composition. I fell into the same trap believing that if I removed all processed food, refined sugar, dairy, etc, that I would get shredded. *I was wrong (and very confused.)*

Which draws down the simple conclusion that when it comes to simple weight loss and weight gain—*a calorie is a calorie*.

This was demonstrated by Professor Mark Haub who was able to [lose 27 pounds over two months](#) on a diet consisting of protein shakes, Twinkies, Oreos, Doritos, and Little Debbie snacks. He calculated he would need to eat about 1,800 calories—his *calorie target*— per day to lose weight without starving himself.

Of course, he doesn't recommend eating garbage food to lose weight. However, he wanted to demonstrate that when it comes to weight loss—*calories are king*.

When it comes to optimising *body composition*, a calorie is *not* a calorie. Let's discuss the importance of tracking your macronutrients to achieve an optimal body composition.

FLEXIBLE DIETING AND BODY COMPOSITION



If you want to improve your *body composition*—or lose fat and maintain or even build muscle— then not only do you need to eat the right number of calories per day, but you also need to pay attention to how your daily calorie requirements break down into your macronutrient goals of protein, carb, and fat.

Macronutrients, or “macros”, is a type of nutrient the body requires in large amounts. The primary macronutrients are protein, carbohydrate, and fat.

If you are just trying to see the number drop on the scale—or simple weight loss—then what you eat matters very little—think of the Professor Mark Haub experiment.

However, if you [eat too little protein](#) while in a calorie deficit then you'll lose more muscle than if you keep your protein levels high. If you [eat too few carbohydrates](#) while in a calorie deficit then muscle repair will be hindered. If you completely cut out dietary fat then [your testosterone levels will plummet](#).

When people are only focused on severely restricting their calorie intake and ignoring their protein, carb, and fat intake—their macronutrient targets—while doing excessive cardio and very little strength training—leads to the inevitable *skinny fat problem* ([watch my skinny fat transformation story here](#).)

If you want your bulking or cutting ambitions to be successful—and avoid the dreaded skinny fat look—then you need to eat enough protein and carbohydrate to preserve muscle and enhance training performance, and enough dietary fat to maintain healthy levels of hormone function.

In summary, what you eat *matters* if you are trying to lose fat and *not* muscle—not just simply “losing weight.”

FOOD CHOICES AND FLEXIBLE DIETING



As you've learned, you don't gain weight by eating the "wrong" food or lose weight by "eating clean." Weight gain occurs by eating too much food and to lose weight, you need to eat less food than your body requires to maintain its current weight.

The more you become familiar with the ideologies of flexible dieting or IIFYM, the more you'll realise that it is more of a *lifestyle* than a "diet" per se.

Flexible dieting is the most effective way to lose weight when implemented correctly. There are people who abuse the concepts of flexible dieting by eating as much junk food as possible while hitting their calorie and macro targets. Although it "works" it's not very satiating and you'll end up developing nutrient deficiencies and other health related complications.

This is how I like to implement the power of flexible dieting in my own life to meet my own calorie and macro requirements.

Aim to get at least 80 to 90% of your total daily calorie allowance from nutrient dense food—or food that is minimally processed and nutritious—and the remaining 10 to 20% from your favourite indulgences.

Simply leverage the power of flexible dieting by eating healthy food that you like every day and working them into your flexible meal plan, while hitting your calorie and macro requirements.

Unless you have specific health requirements—you can include chicken, beef, seafood, legumes, pasta, rice, oatmeal, in any sized portion you wish. Flexible dieting is not concerned with whether you are vegan or vegetarian, prefer intermittent fasting or keto.

It only cares that provided you set your daily calorie target and macros for the goal you are trying to achieve—either to bulk or cut—then all you need to do is pick and choose food that meets your calorie and macro targets every day.

And of course, integrating your favourite “cheat food” into your flexible meal plan will make your journey to either get shredded or build muscle, so much more enjoyable. Personally, I like to incorporate lattes (with sugar), Halo Top ice cream, and Quest Bars. Just ensure you determine the macronutrient breakdown of the cheat food you wish to incorporate.

I use the food database in either [MyNetDiary](#) or [MyFitnessPal](#) to determine the macronutrient values of various food items.

You can budget these “cheat food calories” however you want throughout the week—eating small 100 to 200 calorie cheat snacks every day or a giant cheat meal once or twice per week. Feel free to “save up” your discretionary calories for “pizza night” on the weekend. The choice is yours!

CHOOSE YOUR OWN MEAL TIMING AND FREQUENCY



In the world of flexible dieting, meal timing and meal frequency are not going to impact your ambitions of losing fat or building muscle—provided you are managing your calorie and macronutrient targets correctly.

If you want to skip breakfast, no problems. If you want 2, 4, or 6 meals per day—with or without carbs—no problems!

As you know, I worked night shift for 9.5 years and almost all my calories were consumed between 8.30 pm and 7.00 am. I was eating “lunch” at midnight and my “afternoon snack” in the early hours of the morning.

I'm living proof that you can get absolutely shredded by eating at the weirdest hours of the night—provided you adhere to the concepts of energy balance discussed earlier.

If you are taking up a serious weightlifting regimen then I suggest incorporating a pre- and post-workout meal around your weightlifting sessions.

I recommend your flexible meal plans incorporate 30 to 40 grams of whey protein (concentrate or isolate) pre- and post-workout and 30 to 40 grams of any type of carbohydrate pre- and post-workout. And by “any type of carbohydrate” I mean, anything from simple sugars and fruit, to dates, figs, and raisins.

If you look at the supplied flexible meal plan, you can manipulate the meal frequency and meal timing according to your preferences and lifestyle. You'll need to delete (or add) rows and make simple changes to the formulas, so all cells tally correctly at the bottom of the spreadsheet.

In conclusion, contrary to popular myth, eating fewer or more meals each day is not going to impact your fat loss or muscle building goals. Your metabolism isn't going to slow down if you only eat two meals per day versus six and you don't need to eat protein every 2- to 3- hours to avoid losing your muscle.

If you create and follow your flexible meal plan that suits your preferences and lifestyle—like I did with my corporate night shift roster—you'll be totally okay.

Trust the process and be patient 😊

Let's move into the Frequently Asked Questions section where I'll answer some of your questions directly.

FREQUENTLY ASKED QUESTIONS



Q 1

DO I REALLY NEED TO TRACK MY CALORIES AND MACROS TO GET SHREDDED OR TO BUILD MUSCLE?

The short answer is... ***no you don't***. However, correctly tracking and counting calories—as well as macronutrients—is the most effortless way to go about it.

While you are bulking or cutting using these flexible meal plan templates, you need to hit your daily calorie target and macros—and accurately to ***within 100 to 150 calories***.

However, what is unique about these flexible meal plan templates is that you won't have to kiss all your favourite food goodbye! I won't be saying that you need to cut out all grains, high-glycaemic carbs, processed foods, dairy, fruit, granola, gluten and... sugar?

One of the main reasons why tracking calories and macros doesn't work for most people is they perceive meal planning or using apps like [MyFitnessPal](#), a psychological burden. However, people are quick to change their minds—including myself—when they are taught how to track calories and macros while having no hunger, restrictions over food choices, and zero cravings.

The biggest catch? ***Don't exceed your daily calorie target***. I like to use a *sanity buffer* of being within 100 to 150 calories of my daily target calories. It's not practical nor psychologically healthy to try and hit your daily calorie target *precisely*.

Just remember to remove all the sample entries inside of the flexible meal plan templates and replace them with your own. Enter food ***you*** enjoy eating while hitting your calorie and macro targets.

Q 2

CAN I CHANGE THE FOOD ITEMS IN MY FLEXIBLE MEAL PLAN?

Yes! The flexible meal plan templates are designed so that you can remove the default entries and enter in your own food choices. You need to ensure the calories and macros for the food items you enter approximately match the *four target numbers* (i.e., total calories, protein, carb, and fat) at the bottom of the spreadsheet.

You'll need to manipulate portion sizes—using [MyNetDiary](#) as a reference—to ensure you are hitting your *total daily calories* to within 100 to 150 calories (i.e., the “sanity buffer”).

Over the years, I've used the food database within MyNetDiary to obtain all my macronutrient data to create my own flexible meal plans. Feel free to also use the food database within [MyFitnessPal](#), which contains over 11 million foods in their database.

Before MyNetDiary, I used to use [CalorieKing.com](#)—an online food database that is very much still relevant today. If you don't want to download apps onto your phone then just visit the CalorieKing website and use the search tool.

Q 3

SHOULD I WEIGH MY FOOD COOKED OR RAW/UNCOOKED?

It is more accurate to weigh and measure food *before* cooking. Nutrition labels will give information related to food in its packaged or *uncooked* state. Cooking food will change its weight so much so that meat and seafood can lose up to 20 to 25% of its weight and volume.

Vegetables can lose up to 50% of their weight and volume.

For example, the weight of *raw chicken breast* will be heavier until it's cooked, due to the water content leaving during the cooking process.

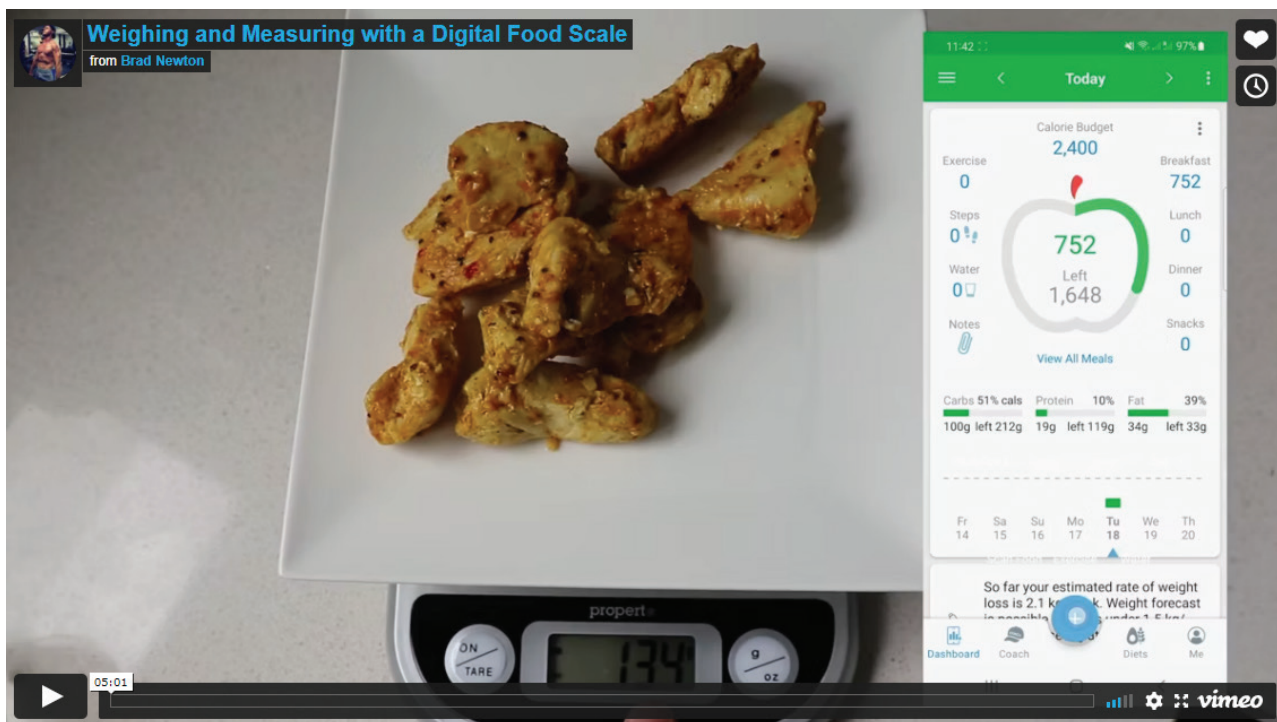
To keep this process simple, I suggest weighing all food on a [digital kitchen food scale](#) and [measuring cups and spoons](#)—*either* cooked or raw. However, ensure you are using the correct entries inside of MyNetDiary for food items listed as either cooked or raw.

In other words, if you are weighing chicken breast *cooked* then ensure that you search “roasted chicken breast,” or “chicken breast *cooked*,” or something similar, inside MyNetDiary to find the correct calorie and macronutrient data.

Alternatively, if you are weighing *raw chicken breast* then search “chicken breast raw,” or something similar, inside MyNetDiary.

Although it is more accurate to measure and weigh food in its uncooked state, when it comes to tracking your calories and macros, provided you select the correct entries associated with “cooked” or “raw” inside MyNetDiary, it doesn't matter.

I've decided to include a video tutorial (taken from my *Ultimate Body Transformation* program) which demonstrates the use of a digital food scale. *Click on the thumbnail below to watch it.*



CLICK HERE TO WATCH

Q 4 ARE MY DAILY TARGET CALORIES “NET CALORIES” OR “TOTAL CALORIES”?

To clarify, *net calories* is the difference between the energy you consume and the energy you burn through training. The calculation becomes:

$$\text{Net Calories} = \text{Calories Consumed} - \text{Calories Burned (Training)}$$

The daily target calories you’ve calculated using the [online macronutrient calculator](#) (click link) is already factoring in your *anticipated* activity levels.

Do not subtract your calories burned from exercise or training from the daily target calories you’ve calculated using the online macronutrient calculator.

For example, my daily target calories of around 2,000 calories are my *net calories* for *cutting* and it will assume I will be undertaking 4 to 5 hours of training per week (i.e., the Activity Factor.)

Q 5

CAN YOU PLEASE CHECK MY MEAL PLAN AND CONFIRM MY BODY PERCENTAGE?

I am happy to give you tips to help you reach your total daily calories and macronutrient targets. If you have any specific health conditions then I suggest seeking the help of a registered dietitian.

Given the volume of emails I receive, I am not able to do a “body fat percentage check” for everyone. I’ve included body fat percentage tables in this guide for you to compare yourself and find your *approximate* body fat percentage.

It is ***not necessary*** to know your *exact* body fat percentage. An approximation is enough.

Q 6

SHOULD I BE “EATING BACK” THE CALORIES I BURN EVERY DAY?

Don’t eat back your calories. If you “eat back” your calories while in a calorie *deficit* for fat loss then you’ll be thrown out of a calorie deficit. Likewise, eating back your calories while in a calorie *surplus* for building muscle will create a larger surplus leading to a disproportionate increase in fat gain over muscle.

There are exceptions to the rule. If you are in a *calorie deficit* with your target calories set to, for example, 2,000 calories per day—assuming 4 to 5 hours of training per week—then eating back some calories would be necessary if you’ve undertaken more training than planned.

Likewise, if you’ve set your target calories for *bulking* at, for example, 3,500 calories—assuming 4 to 5 hours of training per week—would require that you eat back calories if you’ve decided to do an extra 3 hours of kickboxing training for the week. In this scenario, failing to eat back your calories will mean the excess cardio would throw you out of a calorie surplus and into a deficit (not ideal if you are trying to bulk.)

To keep it simple. While you are following the flexible meal plan template, stick to meeting your total daily calorie and macronutrient obligations, and set training regimen. Only make tweaks and changes to your meal plan template or training regimen if you’ve plateaued (discussed later.)

Q 7 SHOULD I BULK OR CUT FIRST? I’M CONFUSED...

This is quite easily one of the most common questions I receive. This question usually comes from people that are struggling with a “skinny fat” physique (a problem I once had—[watch my skinny fat transformation story here.](#))

The answer is relatively straightforward. Ask yourself these two questions.

1 What is your **main goal** right now?

2 What is your current *approximate* body fat percentage?

If your **main goal** is to gain more size, more strength, and set personal bests in the gym, then provided your body fat percentage is hovering around 10 to 13% (for guys,) I would suggest start with a *bulking phase*. If your body fat percentage is over 20% (for guys) then start with a *cutting phase* until you reach 10 to 13% then re-assess.

If your **main goal** is to get shredded, see a six pack and muscle definition—maybe due to an upcoming wedding or special event—then I'd suggest start with the *cutting phase*.

Keep in mind that most people will usually need two proper bulk/cut cycles to completely realise their physique dreams. No matter whether you choose to bulk, cut, or do a "body re-composition" (discussed later,) you'll *eventually* reach the end goal of a strong, lean, and muscular physique.

Don't overthink this process. Deciding on whether you should bulk or cut first is negligible. It's more important to focus on hitting your daily target and macronutrient needs, learning how to lift in the gym, being patient, and trusting the process. If you apply these ingredients, your body *will* transform.

Q 8

I'M STRUGGLING TO GET OVER 150 GRAMS OF PROTEIN A DAY! IS IT NECESSARY? ANY IDEAS?

One of the biggest struggles I faced when I started my flexible dieting journey and tracking my macros was trying to hit my *protein* macronutrient target. When I calculated my macros, I was initially aiming to hit 150 grams of protein per day.

It was a real struggle because I wasn't informed on good sources of protein and was not strategic in how to intake such a large amount of protein.

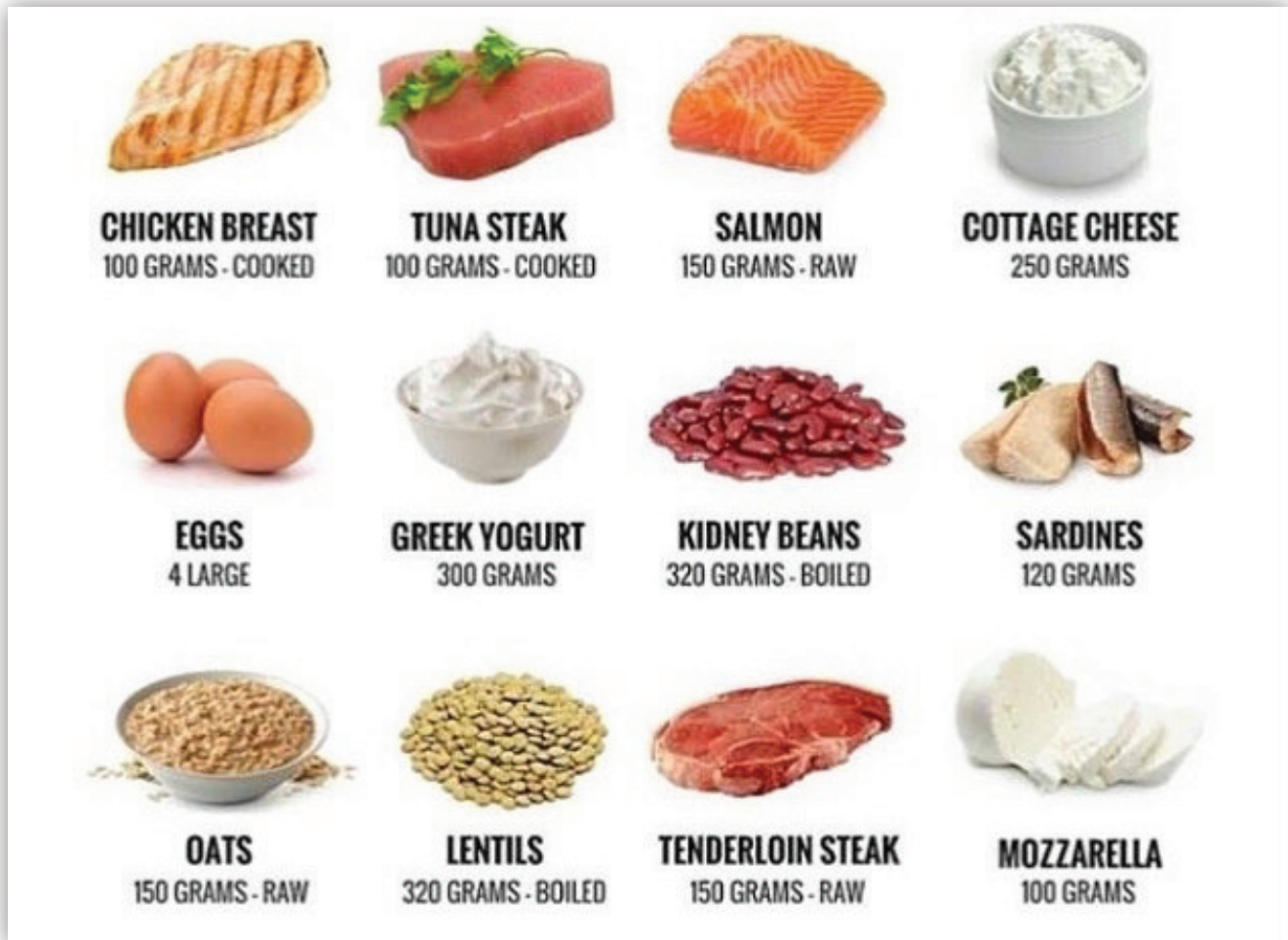
Before I give you practical advice on how to hit your protein target for the day, I want to share the reason why you must keep your protein levels high while in a calorie deficit to lose weight.

The research is clear, if your primary objective is to shred fat without losing your muscle mass then a high-protein diet is far superior for [losing fat faster](#) and [maintaining muscle](#).

In [another study](#) by McMaster University, to maximise building muscle, a protein intake of between 0.6 to 0.8 grams per pound of body weight *per day* is necessary.

If you are still not convinced that your protein intake needs to be significantly higher as a new trainee in the gym—or if you are calorie restricted to lose fat—then check out the [Optimal Protein Intake Guide](#) on Examine.com.

Let's look at what **30 grams of protein** looks like for various sources of protein.



Personally, when I am constructing my flexible meal plans for either cutting or bulking, I'll start by assigning **30 grams** of *whey protein* pre- and post-workout. That means I'll be getting *60 grams* of protein around my weightlifting workout leaving the remaining protein balance to my prepared meals and high protein snacks.

I always strive to have a protein source in every main meal, and usually 30 to 40 grams of protein per *main meal*. Using the graphic above, 30 grams of protein translates to 100 grams of chicken breast, or 100 grams of tuna steak, 150 grams of salmon, 150 grams of tilapia, etc.

I have come across people that believed that 100 grams of chicken contains 100 grams of protein. Or that by simply “eating more nuts” instantly translates to “I’m getting enough protein!”

Let’s look at high protein snacks.

Typically, outside of my main meals, I’ll plan to have 2 to 3 high protein snacks that I’ll have whenever I’m starting to feel hungry from being in a calorie deficit.

Below is an example of a few quick and easy high protein snack ideas to fill into your flexible meal plan between your main meals.



3 oz of beef jerky



1 cup of cottage cheese



3 oz can of tuna



1 cup of Greek yogurt & nuts



1 scoop of protein powder



Protein waffles with peanut butter & milk



Homemade protein bar



3 hardboiled egg whites & 2 eggs

Personally, my high protein snacks usually consist of a Quest protein bar (20 grams of protein), a can of tuna or salmon, and several hardboiled eggs. Sometimes I'll have another 30-gram whey protein shake.

Spend some time researching "high protein snacks" and consider incorporating them into your flexible meal plan to help you meet your daily protein obligations. It will take some time but persevere! I can assure you that meeting your daily protein requirement will eventually become second nature. Trust the process 😊

Q 9 WHAT IF I OVER-EAT OR HAVE AN OUTRIGHT BINGE SESSION?

The slippery slope of mainstream dieting that we have all fallen into looks like this.

Overly restrictive, very low-calorie diets lead to cravings. Cravings lead to "cheating." Cheating leads to binge-eating and binge-eating leads to quitting.

Therefore, the flexible dieting approach is so effective because it utilises the ideology of removing all the psychological burden associated with dietary restrictions. The only "restriction" of flexible dieting is ensuring you do not exceed your daily calorie and macronutrient targets.

However, there will be times when you will have to attend weddings, birthdays, travel for work, or other commitments that go against your "well designed" flexible meal plan. Or perhaps you decided to smash the entire block of

chocolate on a Friday night instead of the three squares you originally planned for in the flexible meal plan.

This binge-eating spree may have rolled over into the following day where you've completely over-eaten days' worth of excess calories—gaining fat and looking bloated.

Does that mean you've completely failed? Absolutely not! Even with my own flexible meal plans, I've had moments of all-out late night binge eating. My strategy is to wake up the next day and start from scratch and forget about yesterday.

Here is a video that I've decided to include which is from my Ultimate Body Transformation program. It's called "80% Consistency" and it will help you **take a deep breath, keep calm, and move forward** from any binge-eating sessions you might encounter. Click on the thumbnail below to watch it.



[CLICK HERE TO WATCH](#)

Q 10 HOW MUCH WEIGHT SHOULD I EXPECT TO LOSE PER WEEK WHILE CUTTING?

You should expect to lose 0.5 to 1% of your body weight per week, or around **1 to 2 pounds of weight per week**. This is considered safe, healthy, and realistic ([Helmes et al., 2014](#)).

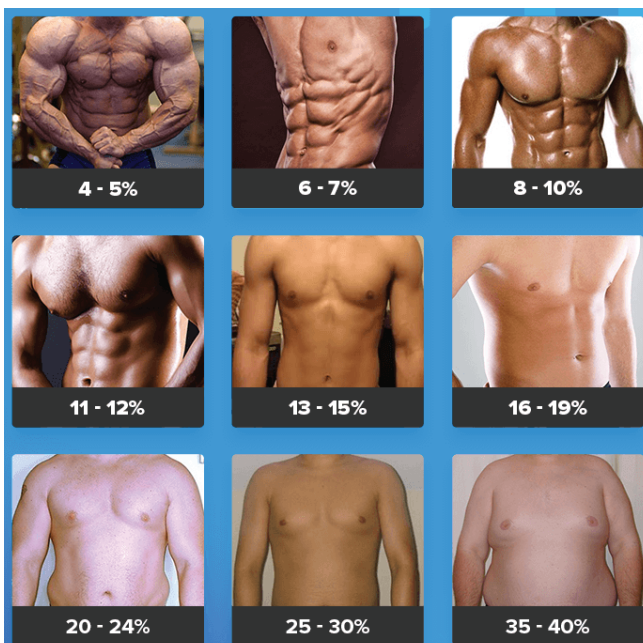
In a 12-week period, you should expect to lose **12 to 24 pounds of weight**.

However, the speed of weight loss (or fat loss) is heavily influenced by your starting body fat percentage. Which means, for men over 25% body fat and women over 35%, you'll be able to lose **2 to 4 pounds of weight per week** (even more if you are extremely obese).

In essence, the more fat you need to lose, the faster you can safely lose it.

Check out the body fat percentage charts below to determine your approximate body fat percentage.

MEN



WOMEN



On the other end of the scale, if you are already very lean and wish to get leaner (for men around 12% body fat and women around 20%), expect to lose **0.5 to 1 pound of fat per week**.

Also keep in mind that weight loss (or fat loss) is a *non-linear journey*. As you become progressively leaner, fat loss will take longer and slow down. *You must have more patience as you get leaner!*

Q 11 HOW MUCH WEIGHT SHOULD I EXPECT TO BULK PER WEEK?

It's extremely important to understand that while you are bulking, you will gain some fat. This is inevitable. In a perfect world, during a bulk you would only put on muscle! But this is simply not true.

If you eat more calories than your target calories for bulking, then you will gain more fat than muscle. If you eat precisely at your target calories for bulking, you will gain more muscle than fat.

Based on [studies by Garthe et al.](#), the following table is a good guide for determining how much weight you can gain per month based on your level of training experience.

WEIGHT GAIN GUIDE (PER MONTH)		
Beginner	Intermediate	Advanced
1% of body weight	0.5% of body weight	0.25% of body weight

As you can see, a beginner has the potential to build more muscle than an Intermediate or Advanced lifter. Typically, the first 6 to 12 months of proper training is where a new trainee can see a rapid increase in strength and muscle building before strength and muscle gain begin to slow down.

Q 12 HOW CAN I FIGURE OUT MY APPROXIMATE BODY FAT PERCENTAGE?

There are several ways. The easiest method (and cheapest) is to compare yourself to the body fat percentage charts (above.) However, don't obsess over trying to get the "exact" body fat percentage. You are just looking for an approximation.

To learn more about the different methods of measuring your body fat percentage, check out this article I wrote: [Body Fat Percentage: Ultimate Guide for Beginners](#).

Q 13 CAN I INCORPORATE A "CHEAT MEAL" OR "CHEAT DAY" IN MY MEAL PLAN?

I recommend avoiding cheat *days* and have either *1 to 2 cheat meals per week*, or smaller 100 to 200 calorie "cheat snacks" throughout the week.

Integrating your favourite "cheat food" into your flexible meal plan will make your journey to either get shredded or build muscle, so much more enjoyable.

Personally, my own flexible meal plan template usually includes **one** Quest protein bar each day and at the end of the week, one tub of Halo Top ice

cream! A Quest bar is around 190 to 220 calories and Halo Top varies between 280 to 380 calories per tub. For me, these were my “cheat snacks” and it made my cutting journey so much more enjoyable.

Just ensure you determine the macronutrient breakdown of the cheat food you wish to incorporate and enter it into your flexible meal plan. I use the food database in either [MyNetDiary](#) or [MyFitnessPal](#) to determine the macronutrient values of various food items, including cheat food.

For example, below are screenshots of the macronutrient breakdown of a Quest bar and Halo Top ice cream from MyNetDiary.

Smore's protein 190 calories bar by <u>Quest Bar</u>		Grade A
Serving Size	1 bar (60g)	
Amount per serving		
Calories	190	
Show % Daily Value New Label		
Total Fat 7g	9%	
Saturated Fat 2.5g	13%	
Trans Fat 0g		
Cholesterol 5mg	2%	
Sodium 200mg	9%	
Total Carbs 22g	8%	
Dietary Fiber 14g	50%	
Total Sugars 1g		
Sugar Alcohols 4g		
Added Sugars 0g	0%	
Net Carbs 4g		
Protein 21g	42%	
Vitamin D 0mcg (0iu)	0%	
Calcium 120mg	9%	

Chocolate protein ice cream by <u>Halo Top</u>		Grade A
Serving Size	4 servings (256g)	
Amount per serving		
Calories	320	
Show % Daily Value New Label		
Total Fat 10g	13%	
Saturated Fat 6g	30%	
Cholesterol 180mg	60%	
Sodium 440mg	19%	
Total Carbs 52g	19%	
Dietary Fiber 8g	29%	
Total Sugars 24g		
Sugar Alcohols 20g		
Net Carbs 24g		
Protein 20g	40%	
Vitamin A 400iu	13%	
Calcium 400mg	31%	
Iron 1.4mg	8%	

If you plan on having a night out with mates then I suggest “saving up” your daily calorie allowance—like money in the bank—and “spending” your allowance on a good night out. Essentially, this will *hedge* against the damage of completely blowing over your daily target calories.

You can budget these “cheat food calories” however you want throughout the week—eating small 100 to 200 calorie cheat snacks every day or a giant cheat meal once or twice per week. Feel free to “save up” your discretionary calories for “pizza night” on the weekend. The choice is yours!

Find your own cheat snacks—or “indulgences” that you enjoy—and include them into the flexible meal plan template using the 80:20 ratio (discussed later.)

Q 14 CAN I DRINK A GLASS OF WINE EVERY NIGHT?

Technically you *could* enter in a glass of wine every night into the meal plan template however—the less alcohol you drink the better your results.

While you are in a cutting phase, I suggest keeping your alcohol indulgences to ***one glass per week*** as a trade-off between “letting loose” and getting shredded.

Q 15 DO I NEED TO DO CARDIO WHILE IN A CUTTING PHASE?

Cardio is **not necessary** for cutting (which surprises many people). Personally, I only introduce cardio into my regimen for cutting if I am trying to get into single digits of body fat.

The best way to include cardio while you are in a cutting phase is to do as little as required to reach your desired rate of weight loss, remain fit and happy, and no more.

If you are not able to include cardio into your regimen during a cut then don't despair. Provided you are hitting your daily calorie and macronutrient targets—without cardio—you will still lose fat.

However, implementing **2 to 3 hours of low intensity cardio per week** can help speed up fat loss.

Here are several methods that I like to deploy when I'm implementing cardio during my cutting phases—and typically after my weightlifting sessions, or on separate days.

- *High-Intensity Interval Training (HIIT)*. This allows you to keep your cardio sessions short and intense. Personally, I incorporate no more than **15 to 20 minutes** of HIIT per session, **2 to 3 times per week**, during my cutting phase. Alternatively, I may opt for low intensity cardio (next method.)

• *Low-Intensity Steady-state Cardio (LISS)*. This may consist of **40 to 60 minutes** per session of rowing, assault bike, jogging, skip rope, rucking, or walking. I would aim to get **2 to 3 hours per week** of LISS (absolute maximum). I usually program low intensity cardio on my “rest days” from weightlifting to minimise fatigue and allow most of my energy to be invested into weightlifting. Sometimes I incorporate LISS (over HIIT) if I need to catch up on podcasts 😊

If you are just beginning your cutting phase and relatively new to cardio, I suggest incorporating **two easy cardio workouts** per week of **30 to 40 minutes per session**. It’s a good place to start which will help boost your calorie expenditure and maintain good health.

Try to implement your cardio and weightlifting sessions on *separate* days. If you can only do them on the same day, separate them by at least 8 hours (if you are doing a split gym session.) If you can only do them in the same gym session then do your cardio workout after your weightlifting session.

If you are an absolute beginner, then I only suggest trying to add small amounts of HIIT into your routine during a cutting phase. Personally, I would start with low intensity cardio and slowly build-up to HIIT due to the physiological stress HIIT can cause on your body. If you don’t incorporate HIIT then it’s not a problem, [the research shows](#) that it’s no more effective for weight loss than low intensity cardio.

Q 16 DO I NEED TO AVOID CARDIO DURING BULKING?

I recommend incorporating cardio, but you'll need to dial it back if you want to consistently maintain a calorie *surplus* during a bulk.

There are reasons for implementing cardio that go beyond the vanity goals of “building muscle.” Such as:

- Maintaining a healthy heart
- Reduced risk of many types of diseases
- Improved insulin sensitivity

And so on.

Many aspiring bodybuilding folks are too focused on building out all their muscle groups and getting completely shredded—while completely shunning cardio as the villain to their ambitions.

Your heart is another muscle—the *cardiac muscle*—which needs to be “trained” with aerobic or anaerobic exercise.

However, too much cardio during a bulk can seriously impact your ability to gain muscle and strength.

I suggest no more than **1 to 2 hours per week** of low intensity cardio—at a *maximum* of **30 to 40 minutes per session**.

Q 17

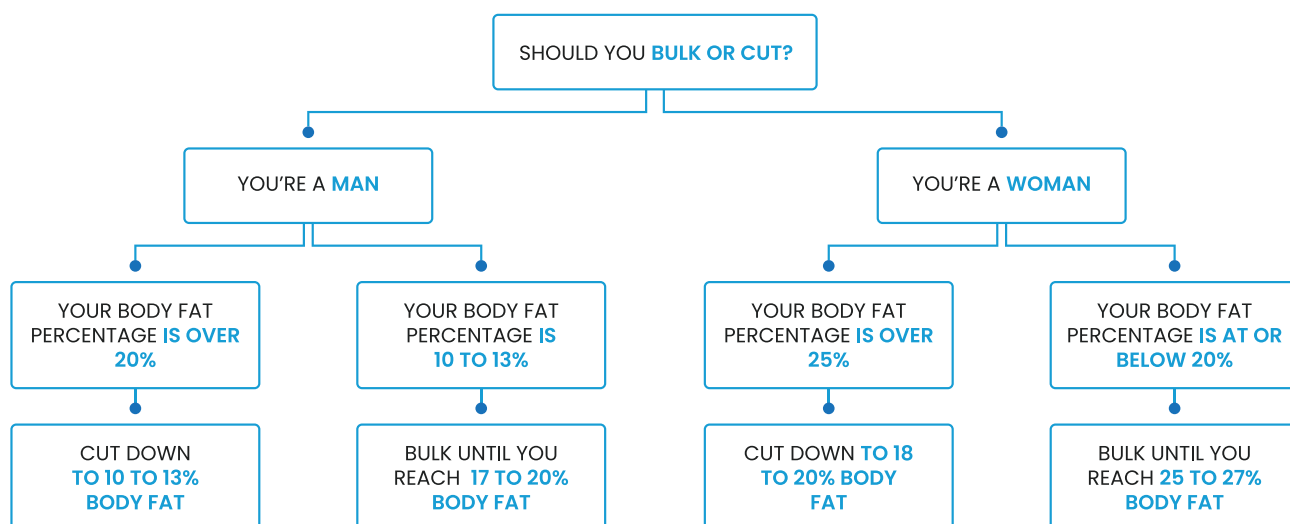
HOW DO I KNOW WHEN IT'S TIME TO SWITCH FROM A BULK TO A CUT, AND VICE VERSA?

Just to recap, *bulking* refers to maintaining a slight calorie surplus, or *positive energy balance*, to increase body weight to maximise muscle. *Cutting* refers to maintaining a slight calorie deficit, or *negative energy balance*, to cause weight loss (or fat loss.)

As you've learned so far, if you wish to commit to a bulking phase then you need to set your daily target calories and macronutrient intake (protein, carbohydrate, and fat) to ensure that most of the weight gained is from muscle rather than fat.

Conversely, committing to a cutting phase means setting your daily target calories and macronutrient intake to ensure the weight that is lost is fat rather than muscle.

Below is a flow chart that summarises when it is time to switch between a bulk and a cut, and vice versa, using your approximate body fat percentage:



You should only bulk if your **main goal** is to gain more size, more strength, set personal bests in the gym, and don't mind gaining *some* fat. Yes, some fat gain during a bulking phase is inevitable, but it will be minimal.

Assuming this is your main goal, you should only commit to bulking if your approximate body fat percentage is:

- 10 to 13% (for guys)
- Below 20% (for women)

If your **main goal** is to get shredded, reveal a six pack, prepare for a fitness photoshoot or other special event, then I suggest start cutting when your approximate body fat percentage is:

- Over 20% (for guys)
- Over 25% (for women)

One reason I suggest commencing a bulk from very low body fat percentages is to remain in a calorie surplus longer. This means more time spent on building muscle.

Below is an extract of my DEXA scan results measuring my body fat percentage for cutting vs bulking. You'll notice that I started one of my bulks from 11.2% body fat and spent 11 months bulking to 16.1% body fat, before commencing a cut.

TOTAL BODY % FAT RESULTS

Scan Date	Age	%Fat	Percentile		Change vs	
			YN	AM	Baseline	Previous
03.03.2017	31	8.30	1	1	-5.0	-4.3
13.09.2016	31	12.6	9	6	-0.7	-3.5
18.02.2016	30	16.1	23	17	2.8	4.9
10.03.2015	29	11.2	6	4	-2.1	-2.2
19.12.2014	29	13.4	12	9	0.2	0.2
18.10.2014	29	13.3	11	8		

End of my second cut and won my first bodybuilding competition

End of my first "cut"

End of my "bulk"

If I had started bulking from a higher body fat percentage then I would end up finishing a bulk being *obese* and spending more time during the cutting phase to bring my body fat percentage level down.

The *length of time* you spend either cutting or bulking depends on how much weight you want to gain or lose. Personally, I wanted to gain a lot of muscle during my bulk and therefore, I opted to remain in a calorie surplus for 11 months. I commenced the cutting phase from 16.1% body fat because I felt it was time to reveal my "gains."

The more experienced a lifter you are, the longer it takes to build muscle and therefore, the longer you need to remain in a calorie surplus to gain muscle.

Some lifters use a bulking-to-cutting ratio of 3:1 where for every 12 weeks spent bulking, is followed by 4 weeks in a cutting phase.

After you've gained some experience with managing your calorie and macronutrient intake, you may prefer to use *mini cuts* and *mini bulks* to shorten the length of your cutting and bulking cycles.

Q 18 HOW DO I TRANSITION FROM A CUT TO A BULK?

When you've arrived at a point in the cutting phase where you are ready to switch to a bulk, you'll need to re-calculate a new daily calorie target and macronutrient profile (using my [online macronutrient calculator](#).)

Just like you did for your flexible meal plan during the cutting phase, you'll enter your new "target numbers" at the bottom of the flexible meal plan spreadsheet and re-adjust your food entries to hit your new target numbers. Again, you should aim to be within 100 to 150 calories of your daily target calories for bulking.

Contrary to popular belief, you **don't** need to gradually *reverse diet* out of a cutting phase and into a bulking phase by incrementally increasing your daily calorie intake each week.

Once you have finished your cutting phase, simply determine your new calorie and macronutrient targets, and begin the bulking phase immediately.

Conversely, when you've reached the end of your bulking phase, determine your new calorie and macronutrient targets, and immediately commence a cut. *No transition period is required.*

Q 19 CAN I CUT AND BULK AT THE SAME TIME?

If you are an absolute beginner and in your first year of proper weightlifting and dieting then, as a guy, you should expect to gain anywhere from 15 to 25 pounds of muscle (half that for a woman.) This is known as “newbie gains” but it doesn’t last forever.

As a beginner, it is possible to build muscle and lose fat *simultaneously*—or achieve a **body re-composition**—when you are just beginning your lifting journey.

After the *newbie phase* is over, your goal will need to be either to lose fat while maintaining muscle (i.e., maintain a calorie deficit) or to gain muscle while minimising fat gain (i.e., maintain a calorie surplus.)

Physiologically speaking, after you’ve surpassed the newbie phase; losing fat, and building muscle are mutually incompatible due to their relationship to the concepts of energy balance.

Q 20 WON'T I GAIN MUSCLE FASTER IF I EAT AS MUCH AS POSSIBLE, WITHOUT TRACKING MY CALORIES?

In the early days of my transformation journey, I made the mistake of believing that if maintaining a *slight* calorie surplus was necessary for building muscle, then *overeating* would yield significantly more muscle.

I was wrong.

You cannot force your muscles to grow faster by “drowning them” in surplus calories. Beyond a certain point, the excess calories you consume will no longer be shuttled into fuelling muscle growth. Instead, they’ll just make you disproportionately fatter!

In the bodybuilding world, this is known as “dirty bulking”—or eating everything you can get your hands on—and it should be avoided.

The same methodical approach to controlling your calorie and macronutrient intake for the cutting phase is also required while you are in the bulking phase.

If you want to maximise your gains while in a bulking phase then you need to maintain a slight calorie surplus—or eat around 110% of your total daily energy expenditure (TDEE) every day.

Below is a snapshot of a section of [my online macronutrient calculator](#) set to “Bulk—Maximum Muscle Gain”. You’ll notice the calculator will take your TDEE value and add 10% to it to give you your daily calorie target for *bulking* (i.e., Total Calories.)

LBM	80 kgs.
BMR	2114
TDEE	2959 calories per day
Presets	Bulk - Maximum Muscle Gain ▾
Deficit ☐ Surplus ☒	+10%
Total Calories	3255
Protein 26%	209g 836 kcal
Carbs 57%	464g 1855 kcal
Fat 17%	63g 564 kcal

Ensuring that you set your daily calorie target to no more than 10% above your TDEE will ensure a bulking phase that will minimise fat gain. Also known as a “lean bulk.”

Q 21

WHAT WEIGHT TRAINING PROGRAM DO YOU RECOMMEND WHILE ON A CUTTING OR BULKING MEAL PLAN?

As an absolute beginner that is in a bulking phase and you want to build muscle as fast as possible, [research shows](#) that you need to predominately focus on ***compound weightlifting***.

In addition to compound lifting, you need to focus on *progressively overloading* your muscles by making your workouts more challenging over time.

The easiest way to emphasise progressive overload as a beginner is to add weight or reps to every compound exercise in every workout, week after week. In other words, if your bench press was 60 kg for 7 reps last week, then you'll strive to bench press 65 kg for 7 reps this week.

This simple approach forces your muscles to produce greater levels of mechanical tension over time. When combined with a bulking phase, will help you grow bigger and stronger.

It's also *essential* that you track all your weightlifting to ensure you are progressing on your compound lifts from week to week. Personally, I use [FitNotes](#) and I've been using it consistently for over 7 years. It's great to scroll back to 2015 and see just how far I've come.

If you are on a *cutting phase* then your exercise selection and focus on compound weightlifting is the same as bulking. Your primary ambition while in a calorie deficit is to maintain as much muscle as possible while shredding fat—and one of the most effective ways of going about this is compound weightlifting.

If you'd like to learn more about one of the most popular beginner lifting programs you can follow while bulking or cutting, I recommend reading the article I wrote: [Push Pull Legs—The Ultimate Beginner Guide](#). I can attest most of my fitness transformation to consistently implementing Push Pull Legs.

Personally, I was implementing Push Pull Legs while I was in a bulking phase and a cutting phase.

Q 22 WHAT BRANDS OF FOOD SHOULD I USE IN MY FLEXIBLE MEAL PLAN?

You should always buy the brands of food you enjoy and fits within your budget.

Be mindful that many brands of food can be found in MyNetDiary and can contain different macros and calories than other brands—for the same portion sizes.

Make sure you select the correct brand inside MyNetDiary when determining the macros of that food item.

Therefore, the brand of food you buy will *not* impact your bulking or cutting goals provided you are within your daily target calories by 100 to 150 calories.

Q 23 WHEN SHOULD I EAT MY FOOD ON THE FLEXIBLE MEAL PLAN?

The impact that *meal timing and meal frequency* has on your cutting or bulking efforts is *negligible*.

Personally, I adapted the 2,000-calorie meal plan template while I was working corporate night shift! My “lunch” was at midnight and my “mid afternoon snack” was at 2 am in the morning. This did not stop me from getting completely shredded for bodybuilding competitions.

The most important factor is determining a meal timing and meal frequency that suits your lifestyle and work/life balance. Except, try to stick to pre- and post-workout meals that are within 30 minutes to an hour around your weightlifting sessions.

The meal plan templates provide a sample structure that can be easily manipulated if you prefer different meal timings and meal frequencies. If you wish to skip breakfast—that is completely fine.

If you are *intermittent fasting* then remove all food items on the meal plan template for your fasting window. Ensure you are hitting your target calories and macros—within 100 to 150 calories—during your feeding window.

In summary, it doesn't matter how many meals you decide to have or the time of day you eat them—provided you are hitting your calorie and macro targets for the day—you will still successfully cut or bulk.

Q 24

IS FOOD PREPARATION AN IMPORTANT CONSIDERATION TO MY CUTTING AND BULKING AMBITIONS?

Nope! It is up to you when choosing how you wish to prepare your food on the meal plan. However, *you must* track all calorie-containing condiments as these will add calories which you have not accounted for in the meal plan.

When creating your own flexible meal plan using the supplied meal plan templates around the food you enjoy—you must include and account for *all condiments*.

These include:

- Sauces
- Oils (I recommend a spray oil. I use a low-calorie coconut spray for cooking)
- Butter
- Nuts
- Sugar
- Creamer
- Salad dressings
- Feta cheese
- Fruit
- All vegetables

One of the biggest mistakes people make in their transformation journey is they overlook these "innocent" calories, but they quickly add up to 100s of extra calories that can very quickly take you out of a calorie deficit (for fat loss.)

As mentioned, I use a low-calorie coconut spray for a non-stick coating to pans.

For me personally, I enjoy a decent coffee—being from Melbourne—and have included that in my own meal plan template for cutting. However, you'll also notice that I've included a teaspoon of sugar.

You can still have sugar—like any of the abovementioned “hidden calories”—but they **must** be entered into your flexible meal planning template.

Q 25 WHAT IS THE “80:20 RULE”?

This means you'll be designing your flexible meal plan templates whereby 80% of your daily target calories will come from relatively unprocessed, nutrient-dense foods, with the remaining 20% from food most diet “gurus” frown upon (i.e., your favourite indulgences.)

The golden rule of flexible dieting is that providing you do not exceed your total daily calories or macronutrient targets, you can essentially eat whatever you want, anytime you want.

However, just because you *can* eat pizzas and donuts all day long that “fit your macros” doesn't mean you *should*. To correctly function, your body needs adequate fibre and a broad spectrum of vitamins and minerals that pizza, donuts, and corn flakes can't help you with.

Q 26 WHAT SPORTS OR TRAINING SUPPLEMENTS SHOULD I TAKE?

Sports supplements are not necessary to get shredded or build muscle. However, if you are hitting your calorie and macro targets—and training correctly—then certain supplements can help you lose fat and gain muscle faster.

There is a small handful of supplements that do have decent scientific research backing their efficacy. However, the most you should expect from these supplements (i.e., creatine monohydrate) is a slight edge over and above what you are already doing with correct nutrition and training.

In this guide, let's look at ***whey protein powder*** and ***creatine monohydrate***.

WHEY PROTEIN POWDER

Whey protein powder is a by-product of the cheese-making process. When milk is curdled and strained, a relatively clear liquid is left over.

This clear liquid contains an impressive array of complete proteins—or amino acid profile—necessary for protein synthesis and hypertrophy. This discovery gave birth to the whey protein supplement industry.

Whey protein is particularly high in *leucine*—an essential amino acid predominately important for initiating protein synthesis.

As you might already be aware, whey protein is a great source of protein. There are three forms you can buy: *concentrate*, *isolate*, and *hydrolysate*. I recommend sticking to a *whey protein isolate* where most of the fat and lactose is removed and is 90+ percent protein by weight.

I have experimented with many different brands and flavours over the years. Just for full disclosure, I am not paid or sponsored by any supplement company, so I am not biased (due to contracts) to plug any brand.

There are many great brands on the market but there's also a lot of garbage, too. I usually default back to **Optimum Nutrition**.



What I like about Optimum Nutrition whey protein is that it only contains 120 calories per scoop, for 24 grams of protein. I usually mix it with unsweetened almond milk or oat milk. I usually order it directly from the [Optimum Nutrition website](#). I'm a big fan.

Once again, not paid or sponsored!

Let's move on and discuss creatine monohydrate.

CREATINE MONOHYDRATE

Creatine is one of the most well-researched sports supplements on the market with over [700+ scientific studies](#) backing its efficacy—from increasing power output to improving cognition.

Our bodies can produce creatine naturally, but it also absorbs, and stores creatine found in various foods like meat, eggs, and fish.

Creatine is an essential ingredient in the process of regenerating cellular energy, which is why supplementing with it increases the amount of work that your muscles can do.

If you start taking creatine, you won't feel the benefits immediately. It takes time to slowly load creatine into the muscle cells to truly realise its benefits.

Also, there are dozens of different types of creatine on the market. *Creatine monohydrate* is the one you need to get.

You can either begin taking creatine by using a *loading phase* or *non-loading phase*. The most common way to start supplementing with creatine is to begin with a loading phase.

The loading phase looks like this:

20 grams per day for 5 to 7 days (split across 5-gram doses), followed by a maintenance dose of 5 grams per day.

You don't have to load creatine if you're just starting with creatine supplementation. You can just start taking a *non-loading phase* amount of 5 grams per day, however starting with a loading phase does cause creatine to accumulate in the muscles sooner.



Personally, I add 5 grams of [Optimum Nutrition creatine monohydrate](#) to my protein shake every day. There's no need to cycle-off it (i.e., stop taking it). Once again, not paid or sponsored by Optimum Nutrition.

There are some additional benefits by taking creatine *with a carbohydrate* to increase creatine accumulation in the muscles. I can usually achieve this by adding a banana to my protein shake.

If you'd like to learn more about other training supplements then I suggest checking out [Examine.com](#). It's a great source of unbiased research on every sports supplement on the market.

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